

Environmental Stewardship

prc-environmental-stewardship

Engagement with World · Creation Care · practice · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus
applies

Statement under examination

Caring for creation as God's stewards is a Christian duty, distinct from creation-worship or pantheist environmentalism.

In plain language

Five anchor texts shape the lexical picture. Genesis 2:15 places the man in the garden with two simple-active Hebrew infinitives (qal infinitive constructs) prefixed by lamed of purpose ('in order to'): 'to work or serve' (abad) and 'to keep or guard' (shamar). The same shamar elsewhere governs guarding a charge, a commandment, or a sanctuary, and abad covers cultivation and service. Together they frame the human task as labor plus protective custody, not ownership. Genesis 1:28 commissions 'have dominion' (radah) and 'subdue' (kabash) inside a divine blessing alongside the calls to be fruitful, multiply, and fill the earth. These dominion verbs carry a forceful semantic core. Kabash elsewhere describes military subjugation and even violent abuse, and radah is genuinely polysemous (carries multiple meanings), used for gentle stewardly rule in some places and for harsh oppressive rule in others. The verbs do not rank these senses on their own. Two texts in the canon constrain them. Leviticus 25:43 commands 'do not rule over him with rigor' (lo tirdeh vo be-farek), applying radah and explicitly forbidding its harsh exercise within the covenant community. Ezekiel 34:4 indicts Israel's shepherds for ruling with force, using the very same verb to name abuse the LORD rejects. So the canon supplies two readings of the dominion verbs (rule and stewardship) and then qualifies the harsh reading from within. Psalm 24:1 then anchors the whole picture: the small prefixed lamed on the divine name marks possession ('belonging to YHWH'), the earth and its fullness belong to YHWH, the world and all who dwell in it. The human relation to creation is therefore custodial and accountable, exercised under a divine Owner. Romans 8:20 adds that the created order, 'creation' (ktisis), was subjected to futility by God and groans awaiting liberation, so creation is neither divine nor mere raw material; it is a subjected order awaiting redemption. The two pro-proposition readings (dominion as rule and dominion as stewardship) converge on affirmation and both exclude treating creation itself as divine.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0776	אֶרֶץ	erets	land	2,505
H1288	בָּרַךְ	barakh	to bless	
H3533	כָּבַשׁ	kabash	to subdue	14
H4390	מָלֵא	male	to fill	
H4393	מְלֵא	melo	fullness	37
H5647	עָבַד	abad	to serve	290

H6509	פָּרָה;	parah	be fruitful	
H7235	רָבָה	ravah	to multiply	
H7287	רָדָה	radah	to rule	18
H8104	שָׁמַר	shamar	to keep	469
H8398	תִּבֵּל	tebel	world	31
G2937	κτίσις	ktisis	creation	19
G3153	ματαιότης	mataiotes	futility	3
G5293	ὑποτάσσω	hupotassō	to subject	

Plain meanings: STEPBible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Three load-bearing texts converge. Genesis 2:15 places the man 'to work it and to keep it' (le-abdah u-le-shamrah), two simple-active infinitive constructs in the qal stem (the simple active form of the Hebrew verb): 'to work or serve' (abad H5647) and 'to keep or guard' (shamar H8104), each governing the garden as object, and syntactically functioning as purpose-clauses on the placing verb. Genesis 1:28 issues 'have dominion' (radah H7287A) and 'subdue' (kabash H3533) within a divine blessing alongside 'be fruitful and multiply' (peru u-revu), so the dominion verbs are delegated, not autonomous. Psalm 24:1 prefixes the lamed of possession (the small Hebrew prefix meaning 'belonging to') to YHWH in 'to-YHWH the-earth-and-its-fullness' (la-YHWH ha-arets u-meloah), marking the earth and all in it as His possession. The combination of delegated rule, custodial keeping, and divine ownership grounds a stewardship reading and forecloses any reading of creation as itself divine or as autonomous human property.

Scripture

Gen.1.28 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H7287A רָדָה, H3533 כָּבַשׁ, H1288 בָּרַךְ, H6509 פָּרָה, H4390 מָלָא.

Reasoning. God blesses the human pair and issues a cluster of imperatives (direct commands): 'be fruitful, multiply, fill' (peru u-revu u-milu), then 'have dominion' (u-redu, from radah in the qal stem, the simple active Hebrew form) and 'subdue it' (kivshuha, from kabash in the qal stem with a third-feminine-singular suffix referring back to the earth). The dominion verbs sit inside the divine blessing 'bless' (barak H1288) and are delegated over fish, birds, and creeping things. 'Have dominion' (radah) carries an attested polysemy (multiple meanings) across the canon: gentle stewardly rule in some contexts and harsh oppressive rule in others. The verbs alone do not rank these senses; the surrounding blessing-frame and the parallel commission in Genesis 2:15 are what tilt the reading toward custodial governance.

Gen.2.15 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H5647 עָבַד, H8104 שָׁמַר.

Reasoning. YHWH Elohim places the man in the garden of Eden 'to work it and to keep it' (le-abdah u-le-shamrah). The ETCBC-BHSA syntactic database (a scholarly grammatical tagging of the Hebrew Bible) tags both verbs as qal infinitive constructs (the simple active Hebrew form in its infinitive 'to do X' shape: vs=qal, vt=inf) prefixed with the lamed of purpose (the small Hebrew prefix meaning 'in order to'): 'to work or serve it' and 'to keep or guard it'. The third-feminine-singular object suffix on each verb refers back to the garden. 'Keep or guard' (shamar) elsewhere governs guarding a charge, a commandment, a covenant, or a sanctuary; 'work or serve' (abad) covers cultivating soil and serving a master. The pairing as twin infinitives of purpose frames the human role over the garden as labor plus protective custody, not possession.

Ps.24.1 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H0776 ארץ, H4393 מלא, H8398 תבל:

Reasoning. The verse opens 'to-YHWH the-earth and-its-fullness, the-world and-those-who-dwell-in-it' (la-YHWH ha-arets u-meloah, tevel ve-yoshvei vah). The prefixed lamed on the divine name (the small Hebrew prefix marking 'belonging to') marks possession: to YHWH belongs the earth and its fullness, the world and those who dwell in it. 'World' (tevel H8398) and 'earth' (erets H0776) form a poetic pair for the inhabited world; 'fullness' (melo H4393) means the totality of contents. The construction grounds any human dominion as derivative and accountable, since the cosmos is His possession, and excludes treating creation itself as divine.

Lev.25.43 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H7287A רדה

Reasoning. Leviticus 25:43 commands 'you shall not rule over him with rigor' (lo tirdeh vo be-farek), do not rule over him with rigor or violence ('rigor', perek). The verse uses the same 'have dominion' (radah) verb as Genesis 1:28 but explicitly qualifies it: an Israelite must not exercise radah with 'rigor' (perek) toward a fellow Israelite. This is a Torah-internal gloss (a definition supplied within the Law itself) on the dominion verb: the verb itself permits a harsh reading, and the Law explicitly prohibits that harsh reading in covenant contexts. By extension, the dominion mandate over creation in Genesis 1:28 takes the same shape: delegated authority that must not become violent exploitation.

Rom.8.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2937 κτίσις, G3153 ματαιότης, G5293 ὑποτάσσω

Reasoning. Paul writes 'for to futility the creation was subjected' (te gar mataioteti he ktisis hupetage), 'for the creation was subjected to futility' ('futility', mataiotes G3153). 'Creation' (ktisis G2937) names the created order as a whole; 'subject' (hupotasso G5293) appears in the aorist passive indicative (a simple statement of completed past action in the passive voice: was subjected), marking a divine act of subjection. Verse 22 adds 'groans together and travails together' (sustenazei kai sunodinei), groaning and travelling together. The vocabulary treats creation as a unified entity acted upon by God and awaiting liberation, which is incompatible with creation being itself divine and incompatible with treating it as mere raw material; it is a subjected order awaiting redemption.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Gen.1.28	Gen.1.22	tsk	1
Gen.2.15	Gen.2.8	tsk	1
Ps.24.1	Ps.50.12	tsk	1
Ps.24.1	Ps.89.11	tsk	1
Gen.1.28	Lev.25.43	openbible	1
Gen.1.28	Ezek.34.4	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Ezek.34.4 · addressed

Ezekiel 34:4 uses the same 'have dominion' (radah) verb (qal, the simple active Hebrew form, glossed 'tread' or 'rule') to indict Israel's shepherds for ruling with force and harshness: 'and with force you have ruled them and with rigor' (u-ve-hozqah reditem otam u-ve-farek). This shows 'have dominion' (radah) is genuinely polysemous (carries multiple meanings) and can describe the very abuse the Lord condemns. It complicates a naive ruling-as-stewardship reading by proving the verb itself permits the harsh sense. The proposition is still supported because Genesis 1:28 places 'have dominion' (radah) inside a blessing of fruitfulness and pairs it with the 'work or serve' (abad) and 'keep or guard' (shamar) of Genesis 2:15, and Leviticus 25:43 explicitly forbids 'have dominion' (radah) with 'rigor' (perek). The canon thus qualifies the dominion verb internally rather than redefining it.

Gen.1.28 · addressed

The dominion verbs 'have dominion' (radah) and 'subdue' (kabash) sound harsh in isolation. 'Subdue' (kabash H3533) elsewhere describes military subjugation (Joshua 18:1, 2 Samuel 8:11, Zechariah 9:15) and even sexual violence (Esther 7:8), so it carries a strong forceful sense. The proposition stands because the verb appears inside a divine blessing alongside fruitfulness imperatives (direct commands), and because the same Torah account in Genesis 2:15 reframes the human role with 'work or serve' (abad) and 'keep or guard' (shamar). The vocabulary does not eliminate the harsh reading; it places it under explicit divine constraint.

Concordance traversed

H7287A, H3533, H5647, H8104, H4393, H0776, H8398, H6509, H7235A, H4390, H1288, G2937, G3153

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

Three Old Testament anchor verses are outside the scope of the ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) and CBGM (the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a tool used in modern textual criticism). Romans 8:20-22 is outside the ingested ECM window (3 John 1:1 to 1:15). No variant units bear on the verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. `dominion_as_rule`, `dominion_as_stewardship`

[analogia scripturae](#) invoked

`dominion_as_stewardship`: for · The infinitives 'to work or serve' (abad) and 'to keep or guard' (shamar) in Genesis 2:15 plus the possessive lamed (the small Hebrew prefix meaning 'belonging to') in Psalm 24:1 and the Torah-internal restraint on 'have dominion' (radah) in Leviticus 25:43 establish a delegated, custodial role under a divine Owner. Romans 8:20-22 names creation as subjected and groaning, so it is neither divine nor raw material but an order awaiting redemption. This lens treats the dominion verbs as constrained from within Scripture.

`dominion_as_rule`: for · 'Have dominion' (radah) and 'subdue' (kabash) carry a genuinely forceful semantic core: tread, subdue, military or judicial dominance. Read on their face, Genesis 1:28 commissions humans to rule and subdue the earth. This lens still supports the proposition because rule from God is delegated and accountable. It rejects framing dominion as merely gentle gardening but agrees that creation is not divine and that human authority is derivative under YHWH. The two lenses converge on the verdict but differ on register: ruling-keeping rather than ruling versus keeping.

`pantheist_or_creation_worship_lens`: against · A lens that identifies creation with the divine would read Psalm 24:1 against itself, treating the earth as itself sacred rather than the LORD's possession. The vocabulary of Psalm 24:1 with the possessive lamed (the small Hebrew prefix meaning 'belonging to') and Romans 8:20 with the aorist passive (a simple statement of completed past action in the passive voice) 'was subjected' (hupetage) of 'creation' (ktisis) to 'futility' (mataiotes) both place the created order under God and distinct from Him, foreclosing any identification. This lens is not lexically supported by the anchor texts.

The verdict turns on the lexical sense of the dominion and keeping verbs, the possessive lamed (the small Hebrew prefix meaning 'belonging to') in Psalm 24:1, and the Torah-internal restraint on 'have dominion' (radah) in Leviticus 25:43. The two pro-proposition lenses (rule and stewardship) converge on affirmation while differing on the rhetorical weight of 'have dominion' (radah) and 'subdue' (kabash).

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. How does Scripture describe the human relation to the created order, what is the lexical force of the dominion verbs ('have dominion', radah, and 'subdue', kabash) and the keeping verbs ('work or serve', abad, and 'keep or guard', shamar) in the creation narratives, and what does the possessive lamed (the small Hebrew prefix meaning 'belonging to') in Psalm 24:1 say about who owns the earth?

The stem embeds an approved conclusion (caring for creation is a Christian duty) and a contrast term (distinct from creation-worship or pantheist environmentalism) that frames the verdict before the text is read. The verdict was derived on the original stem from queried lexical data: 'work or serve' (abad) and 'keep or guard' (shamar) tagged as qal infinitive constructs (the simple active Hebrew form in its infinitive 'to do X' shape) in Genesis 2:15 (ETCBC-BHSA, the scholarly grammatical tagging of the Hebrew Bible), 'have dominion' (radah) and 'subdue' (kabash) as imperatives (direct commands) inside the blessing of Genesis 1:28, the possessive lamed (the small Hebrew prefix meaning 'belonging to') on YHWH in Psalm 24:1, the Torah-internal restraint on 'have dominion' (radah) in Leviticus 25:43 ('do not rule with rigor', lo tirdeh be-farek), and the aorist passive (a simple statement of completed past action in the passive voice) 'was subjected' (hupetage) of 'creation' (ktisis) in Romans 8:20.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.2.15
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.1.28
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H5647
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H8104
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7287A
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H3533
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H4393
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Gen.2.15
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Gen.1.28
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Lev.25.43
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.8.20
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2937
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3153
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Ps.24.1
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Gen.1.28

License audit

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Reason. ETCBC-BHSA syntactic data is licensed CC-BY-NC-4.0 (non-commercial, redistribute=false), so the bundled evidence cannot be redistributed in bulk.

Source	License	Redistribute
OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes

STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
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TSK	public_domain	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

(none)